INTRODUCTION

The rapid and relentless rise of post-2001 terrorism in Pakistan is largely attributed to the birth and evolution of home-grown Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP), Al Qaeda and other affiliated terrorist groups that sneaked into the Federally Administered Tribal Areas (FATA) of Pakistan after the US invasion of Afghanistan. The existing jihadi infrastructure in FATA and elsewhere harboured and supported them and very soon they started challenging the writ of the state. Nevertheless, it was not a sudden spike or unforeseen development. Things had been brewing for the last two decades, in FATA in particular and in Pakistan in general. The state-sponsored jihadi activities to counter the Soviet invasion in Afghanistan had led to the rise of religious extremism and sectarianism in Pakistan. The jihadi parties formed to augment separatist activities in Indian-held Kashmir also added to the religious militancy mood. The soil was already fertile and became favourable for full-blown terrorist activities after 2001.

Unfortunately, the intelligence agencies of Pakistan remained indifferent to the growing threat from the 1980s through to the 1990s until the situation snowballed into a grave threat to the country. From 2001 onwards, within a few years, Al Qaeda, TTP and its affiliates became too strong and well entrenched to be controlled by the security agencies of Pakistan. The state struggled to reduce this threat effectively, thereby challenging its stability and survival.

This threat seriously undermined law and order in Pakistan, damaged social and political standing and, above all, undermined the country's economic growth. The number of casualties and deaths was ever-growing, including civilians, and the members of civil and military forces